

Pulwama, Badgam and Anantnag, Kilo Force in Baramulla, Kupwara and Srinagar, and Uniform Force in Banihal and Udhampur. RR battalions are affiliated to different regiments of the army, and its officers and jawans serve around 30 months in the force. The majority of the Romeo and Uniform Force have been deployed on India's border with China after the 2020 military standoff in Ladakh.

Since RR units are deployed in places categorised as 'disturbed areas', it operates under the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA). However, the power to conduct operations with impunity as afforded by the Act has been problematic, to say the least. In the past, RR personnel have been accused of extra-judicial killings, enforced disappearances and torture of civilians by many, including by Human Rights Watch and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR). The latter has called for an international probe into the allegations. One other matter of concern is civilian casualties as collateral damage in counter-insurgency operations or otherwise—cross-firing, alleged fake encounters, mistaken identity or targeted killings by militants.

According to the military, any insurgency problem has to be addressed through conflict management and conflict resolution. The first normalises and manages the situation, a task handled by the security forces through judicious application of minimum force. Conflict resolution addresses root causes, which are political and need political settlement—involving negotiations to arrive at a mutually acceptable solution. "Any miscalculation in conflict management will most certainly jeopardise conflict resolution," says an army officer.

The RR's main task was to eliminate militancy in the hinterland (as opposed to the border areas), considered to be 'law and order issues', which comes under the Union ministry of home affairs. "The prolonged stay of the RR is detrimental to the national interest as well as to the interest of the Indian Army. The army is not trained in handling law and order. Cases like that involving Maj. Litul Gogoi (who strapped a Kashmiri civilian to his jeep as a human shield during a stone-pelting incident, drawing widespread condemnation) take place because the army is ill-equipped for such situations," says Col. Sanjay Pande, who has served in the RR.

Lt Gen. Ahuja favours a gradual reduction. He says a sudden reduction in RR numbers will adversely impact the robust framework of the counter-terrorism grid for the administration, CAPFs and police to operate in. "As an initial step, it would be desirable to reduce the points of deployment (number of operating bases), say, from six odd bases per RR battalion to maybe three or so," says Lt Gen. Ahuja.

Ajai Sahni, an observer of terrorism in Kashmir and executive director of the Institute for Conflict Management, also doesn't favour the early withdrawal of RR units, as he feels there is no drastic change in militancy in Kashmir. "As the police and paramilitary forces start to take over greater responsibility, the army should be kept for a more peripheral role or maintained as a backup. Depending on the ground assessment, there can be a progressive dilution of the Rashtriya Rifles' role," he says. That seems to be a prudent option: a cautious drawdown, but retaining an option to strike at any spurt of militancy. ■

RIFLES AT THE READY

RR DEPLOYMENT

70,000 men | **65** battalions

DIVIDED INTO FIVE HQS

- Romeo Force in Rajouri and Poonch
- Delta Force in Doda
- Victor Force in Pulwama, Badgam and Anantnag
- Kilo Force in Baramula, Kupwara, Srinagar
- Uniform Force in Banihal and Udhampur

NUMBER OF TERROR INCIDENTS IN KASHMIR

2020	2021	2022
47	35	18

MILITANTS KILLED

2020	2021	2022
143	92	53

RASHTRIYA RIFLES' ANTI-TERRORISM SCORESHEET IN J&K

Neutralised over **16,500** terrorists	Over **9,000** killed
Approx. **6,800** apprehended	Approx. **1,200** surrendered

Source: Indian Army, SATP